

Chasing Lift from Boston

Weekend soaring destinations, operators, fleets and rental paths. Compiled 2026-09-22 for Martin (GBSC student pilot). Companion files: **Chase-Lift Soaring Register.xlsx** (full data, fleet register, contact log) and **Chase-Lift Map.html** (interactive weather + site map).

Bottom line

- **Default to the van.** Seven active sites sit inside roughly 4 hours on a Friday evening: Sugarbush, Franconia, Post Mills, NESAs Springfield, Mohawk North Adams, Adirondack Saratoga and Wurtsboro. Late September through November is Northeast ridge and wave season (northwest flow behind cold fronts).
- **Walk-in rental to a visiting licensed pilot is rare.** Most US soaring is club-based: you join, check out, and pull duty. Operators that publish non-member rental: Sugarbush (VT), Wurtsboro (NY), Van Sant (PA), Chilhowee (TN), Seminole-Lake (FL), Miami Gliders (FL), Arizona Soaring (AZ), and Mile High Gliding (CO, terms unpublished).
- **So yes, you need relationships first.** Every operator, commercial included, expects a checkout on the first visit. The plan is: one good-weather checkout trip per site, then short-notice trips by phone.
- **Best fly-away bets:** Orlando for Seminole-Lake (cheap routes, year-round), Atlanta for Chilhowee (ridge in fall-spring), Phoenix for Arizona Soaring (Oct-Apr, but fares rarely under \$300 last-minute), Denver for Boulder.
- **Tall-pilot filter:** many fleets are ASK-21 heavy. Roomy types to look for: Schweizer 2-33 and 2-32, LET L-23 Super Blanik and L-13, Grob 103 (depends on proportions), Grob 102, DG-505, PW-6 front seat.

1. Travel radius

Drive times are OSRM (Open Source Routing Machine) distances with typical times calibrated against published trips, plus 30-60 min for the Friday 4:30-7:00 pm Boston outbound peak. Treat as plus or minus 15 min.

Site	Airport	Miles	Typical	Fri 5:30 pm	Within 4 h?
GBSC, Sterling MA	3B3	45	0:50	1:15-1:30	Yes
Connecticut Soaring, Windham CT	IJD	84	1:30	2:00	Yes
NESA, Springfield VT	VSF	123	2:15	2:45	Yes
Mohawk, North Adams MA	AQW	~135	2:40	3:10	Yes
Franconia NH	1B5	151	2:30	3:00-3:30	Yes
Post Mills VT	2B9	155	2:40	3:10	Yes
Mt Washington wave camp, Gorham NH	2G8	183	3:15	3:45-4:15	Edge
Sugarbush, Warren VT	0B7	191	3:15	3:45-4:00	Edge
Adirondack, Saratoga NY	5B2	193	3:15	3:45	Yes
Valley Soaring, Middletown NY	06N	~210	3:30	~4:00	Edge
Wurtsboro NY	N82	216	3:30	4:00-4:15	Edge
Blairstown NJ (Jersey Ridge, ACA)	1N7	266	4:15	4:45-5:00	No
Van Sant PA	9N1	276	4:30	5:00+	No (fly PHL)
Harris Hill, Elmira NY	4NY8	360	5:30	6:00+	No (fly SYR)

Flight radius: nonstop from BOS (PVD and MHT add options but are 60-75 min from Newton at rush hour). Earliest realistic BOS departure is about 7:00-7:15 pm. Tier A = plausibly under \$300 booked 2-3 days out; B = sometimes; C = rarely. Fares are KAYAK route-page ranges, Sept 2026; last-minute premiums run 10-100%. Spirit ceased operations 2 May 2026.

Tier	Dest.	Carriers	Friday timing	Fare (RT)	Soaring
A	ORD / MDW	AA, UA / WN	~8-9 pm dep, arr ~10-11 pm CT	\$181-308 typ	Sky Soaring ~0:50; Chicago Glider Club ~1:00
A	PHL	AA, DL, B6	9:29 pm -> 11:09 pm	\$191-347 typ	Van Sant ~1:15; Blairstown ~1:45
A	DCA	AA, DL, B6	earlier than 10:48 pm	\$185-332 typ	Fairfield PA ~1:30; Skyline
A	BWI	WN, DL	10:20 pm -> ~12:00 am	\$213-364; last-minute +103%	Fairfield PA ~1:20
A	ATL	DL, B6, F9	~8 pm dep	\$196-360 typ	Chilhowee ~2:15; MGSA ~1:00
A	MCO	B6, DL, F9	7-8 pm dep	\$209-395 typ	Seminole-Lake ~0:45
A	SYR / BUF	AA, B6, DL	~8:30-9:50 pm	\$197-338 typ	Harris Hill 1:45-2:30
A	RDU	DL, B6, F9	9:45 pm -> 11:56 pm	\$182-346 typ	NCSA ~0:45
B	DEN	UA, WN, B6, DL	9:06 pm -> 11:48 pm MT	\$278-468; avg \$365	Boulder ~0:45
B	CLT	AA, DL	8:10 pm -> 10:44 pm	\$296-429	Bermuda High ~1:15
B	IAD	UA	7:41 pm (tight)	\$226-377	Skyline, Eastern Soaring
B	PIT	B6, DL	9:59 pm -> 11:55 pm	\$233-421	Pittsburgh Soaring ~1:00
B	DTW	DL, B6	9:40 pm -> 11:55 pm	\$237-416	Sandhill ~1:00
B	AUS	DL, B6, WN	7:49 pm -> 11:27 pm CT	\$253-470	Fault Line Flyers ~1:15
B	TPA	B6, DL	earlier than 9:35 pm	\$230-441	Tampa Bay ~0:45; Seminole ~1:15
B	BNA	WN, B6, DL	9:29 pm -> 11:23 pm CT	\$242-432	Eagleville ~0:45; Chilhowee ~3:00
C	PHX	AA, DL, B6	8:29 pm -> 11:21 pm MST	\$307-517; avg \$398	Arizona Soaring ~0:45
C	LAS	B6, DL	8:40 pm -> 11:37 pm PT	\$310-542	LVVSA ~0:30
C	DFW	AA, DL	7:50 pm -> 11:18 pm CT	\$314-540	TSA ~0:50
C	SLC	DL, B6	7:30 pm -> 10:55 pm MT	\$410-665	Heber ~0:55
C	RNO	none nonstop	n/a	n/a	Minden: not reachable Friday night

2. Operators by region

Rank = ease of short-notice rental for a visiting licensed pilot within that region (1 easiest). Full procedures, costs, sources and fleets are in the workbook.

New England

#	Operator	Airport	Access	Soaring	Rental path	Phone
1	Sugarbush Soaring Warren, VT	Warren-Sugarbus h (OB7)	191 mi; 3:15 typical, 3:45-4:00 Fri	Thermal, ridge, wave	Rents to visitors	802-496-2290
2	Greater Boston Soaring Club (home club) Sterling, MA	Sterling (3B3)	45 mi; 0:50 typical, 1:15-1:30 Fri evening	Thermal	Membership required	(field phone not published)
3	Mohawk Soaring Club North Adams, MA	Harriman-and-We st (AQW)	~135 mi; 2:40 typical, 3:10 Fri	Ridge (Mt Greylock, Taconics), thermal	Guest / short-term membership	(not published)
4	Post Mills Soaring Club Post Mills, VT	Post Mills (2B9)	155 mi; 2:40 typical, 3:10 Fri	Thermal	Membership required	802-333-9401
5	New England Soaring Association Springfield, VT	Hartness State (VSF)	123 mi; 2:15 typical, 2:45 Fri	Thermal	Membership required	(not published)
6	Franconia Soaring Association Franconia, NH	Franconia (1B5)	151 mi; 2:30 typical, 3:00-3:30 Fri	Thermal, ridge (C annon/Kinsman), wave	Unknown, call	603-823-5034
7	Connecticut Soaring Association Windham, CT	Windham (IJD)	84 mi; 1:30 typical, 2:00 Fri	Thermal	Membership required	860-202-1866
	Mt Washington Wave Camp (GBSC/Franconia/Post Mills) Gorham, NH	Gorham (2G8)	183 mi; 3:15 typical, 3:45-4:15 Fri	Wave (Mt Washington)	Membership required	(via GBSC)
	Sanford Soaring Sanford, ME	Sanford Seacoast (SFM)	92 mi; 1:40 typical, 2:15 Fri	Thermal, sea breeze	Closed / inactive	
	Spirit Soaring (motorglider rides) Owls Head, ME	Knox County (RKD)	195 mi; 3:15 typical, 3:45-4:00 Fri	Coastal	Closed / inactive	

NY/NJ/PA

#	Operator	Airport	Access	Soaring	Rental path	Phone
1	Wurtsboro Airport / Wurtsboro Flight Mgmt Wurtsboro, NY	Wurtsboro-Sullivan County (N82)	216 mi; 3:30 typical, 4:00-4:15 Fri	Ridge (Shawangunk), thermal	Rents to visitors	(845) 888-2791
2	Van Sant Airport / Bird of Paradise Erwinna, PA	Van Sant (9N1)	PHL + 1:15 (drive 5:00+)	Thermal, some ridge	Rents to visitors	(610) 847-1119
3	Harris Hill Soaring Corp Elmira, NY	Harris Hill Gliderport (4NY8)	5:30 drive; or SYR + 1:45 / BUF + 2:30	Ridge, thermal	Guest / short-term membership	(607) 734-0641
4	Pittsburgh Soaring Association Waynesburg, PA	Greene County (WAY)	PIT + ~1:00	Thermal	Guest / short-term membership	
5	Adirondack Soaring Association Ballston Spa, NY	Saratoga County (5B2)	193 mi; 3:15 typical, 3:45 Fri	Thermal, some ridge	Guest / short-term membership	(518) 693-6849
6	Aero Club Albatross Blairstown, NJ	Blairstown (1N7) + Wurtsboro (N82)	266 mi to Blairstown; 4:45-5:00 Fri (Wurtsboro ~4:00)	Ridge (Kittatinny, Shawangunk), thermal	Membership required	(973) 294-5146
7	Finger Lakes Soaring Club Dansville, NY	Dansville (DSV)	BUF/ROC + ~1:00	Thermal	Guest / short-term membership	(585) 335-5849
8	Jersey Ridge Soaring Blairstown, NJ	Blairstown (1N7)	266 mi; 4:15 typical, 4:45-5:00 Fri; or PHL + 1:45	Ridge (Kittatinny), thermal	Unknown, call	(908) 362-1239
9	Brandywine Soaring Association Toughkenamon, PA	New Garden (N57)	PHL + ~1:00	Thermal	Guest / short-term membership	
10	Valley Soaring Club Middletown, NY	Randall (06N)	~3:30 typical, ~4:00 Fri	Thermal	Unknown, call	(845) 564-2054
11	Philadelphia Glider Council Hilltown, PA	Philadelphia Gliderport (3PA2)	PHL + ~1:00	Thermal	Membership required	215-334-5980
13	Soaring Tigers Erwinna, PA	Van Sant (9N1)	PHL + 1:15	Thermal	Membership required	(610) 847-1119
14	Long Island Soaring Association Shirley, NY	Brookhaven Calabro (HWV)	4+ h	Thermal (flat coastal)	Membership required	631-578-8596

Mid-Atlantic

#	Operator	Airport	Access	Soaring	Rental path	Phone
2	Skyline Soaring Club Front Royal, VA	Front Royal (FRR); at Petersburg WV (W99) from 16 Sep 2026	IAD + ~1:00 (Petersburg ~2:45)	Thermal, ridge; wave at Petersburg	Guest / short-term membership	
5	Blue Ridge Soaring Society New Castle, VA	New Castle (VA85)	IAD/CLT/RDU + 3:30-4:00	Ridge, wave (to 23,000 ft), thermal	Guest / short-term membership	540-864-5800 (airport owner)
6	Shenandoah Valley Soaring Nellysford, VA	Rockfish Gliderport (VG22)	IAD/DCA + ~2:45-3:00	Thermal, ridge	Guest / short-term membership	
12	Mid-Atlantic Soaring Association Fairfield, PA	Fairfield (W73)	BWI/IAD + ~1:30	Thermal, ridge, wave	Membership required	717-642-9907 (airport)
	Eastern Soaring Center Petersburg, WV	Grant County (W99)	IAD + ~2:45	Thermal, ridge, wave (FL230 window)	Closed / inactive	304-851-4106
	Tidewater Soaring Society Windsor, VA	Garner (3VA8)	RDU + 2:45	Thermal	Membership required	757-377-6174 (landing permission)

Southeast

#	Operator	Airport	Access	Soaring	Rental path	Phone
1	Chilhowee Gliderport Benton, TN	Chilhowee (92A)	ATL + 2:15; BNA + 3:00	Thermal (spring-fall), ridge (fall-spring), occasional wave	Rents to visitors	423-338-2000 (cell 423-506-9015)
4	Bermuda High Soaring Jefferson, SC	Bermuda High Gliderport (SC79)	CLT + 1:15	Thermal	Unknown, call	(803) 475-7627
	Carolina Soaring Association Spartanburg, SC	Spartanburg Downtown (SPA)	CLT + 1:15	Thermal	Membership required	864-256-1741
	North Carolina Soaring Association Bunn, NC	Crooked Creek (7NC5)	RDU + 0:45	Thermal	Membership required	919-215-1356 (field owner)
	Mid-Georgia Soaring Association Monroe, GA	Monroe (D73)	ATL + 1:00	Thermal	Membership required	
	Eagleville Soaring Club Eagleville, TN	Puckett Gliderport (50M)	BNA + 0:45	Thermal	Membership required	800-306-6690

Midwest

#	Operator	Airport	Access	Soaring	Rental path	Phone
3	Sandhill Soaring Club Gregory, MI	Richmond Field (69G)	DTW + 1:00	Thermal	Guest / short-term membership	734-498-2075 (field mgr)
	Sky Soaring Hampshire, IL	Sky Soaring (55LL)	ORD + 0:50	Thermal	Membership required	(847) 683-7627
	Chicago Glider Club Minooka, IL	Chicago Glider Club (IL59)	MDW + 0:50	Thermal	Membership required	630-854-9456
	Caesar Creek Soaring Club Waynesville, OH	Caesar Creek Gliderport (2OH9)	CMH + 1:15	Thermal	Membership required	513-932-7627

Florida

#	Operator	Airport	Access	Soaring	Rental path	Phone
1	Seminole-Lake Gliderport Clermont, FL	Seminole Lake Gliderport (6FL0)	MCO + 0:45	Thermal, sea-breeze convergence; best Mar-May	Rents to visitors	352-394-5450
3	Miami Gliders Homestead, FL	Homestead General (X51)	MIA + 0:50; FLL + 1:15	Thermal	Rents to visitors	(786) 243-7640
11	Tampa Bay Soaring Society Zephyrhills, FL	Zephyrhills (ZPH)	TPA + 0:45	Thermal	Membership required	813-780-0031

Texas

#	Operator	Airport	Access	Soaring	Rental path	Phone
5	Texas Soaring Association Midlothian, TX	TSA Gliderport (TA11)	DFW + 0:50 (Tier C fares)	Thermal; best Apr-Sep	Guest / short-term membership	972-775-4234
6	Soaring Club of Houston Waller, TX	SCH Gliderport (89TA)	IAH + 1:00	Thermal	Guest / short-term membership	
8	Fault Line Flyers Briggs/Bertram, TX	FLF field (private)	AUS + 1:15	Thermal	Guest / short-term membership	(512) 489-0460

Mountain West

#	Operator	Airport	Access	Soaring	Rental path	Phone
4	Mile High Gliding Boulder, CO	Boulder Municipal (BDU)	DEN + 0:45	Mountain thermal; wave Nov-Mar	Rents to visitors	(303) 527-1122
7	Soaring Society of Boulder Boulder, CO	Boulder Municipal (BDU)	DEN + 0:45	Mountain thermal, wave	Guest / short-term membership	
10	Utah Soaring Association / Soar Utah Heber City, UT	Heber Valley (HCR)	SLC + 0:55 (Tier C fares)	High thermal, wave; May-Sep	Membership required	801-979-8482 (CFI Lynn Alley)

Southwest

#	Operator	Airport	Access	Soaring	Rental path	Phone
1	Arizona Soaring (Estrella Sailport) Maricopa, AZ	Estrella Sailport (E68)	PHX + 0:45 (Tier C fares)	Desert thermal; best Oct-Apr	Rents to visitors	(520) 568-2318
9	Las Vegas Valley Soaring Association Jean, NV	Jean (0L7)	LAS + 0:30 (Tier C fares)	Thermal Mar-Nov; wave winter	Membership required	702-267-7499 (rides)
	Merlin Aviation Moriarty, NM	Moriarty (0E0)	ABQ + 0:45 (connection likely)	Very strong thermal	Unknown, call	(505) 226-5556
	SoaringNV Minden, NV	Minden-Tahoe (MEV)	No BOS nonstop to RNO	Wave, thermal (world class)	Rents to visitors	(775) 790-8041

3. How renting works for a visitor

Across the operators researched, the path to flying a glider solo at a site that is not your home club falls into four patterns:

- **Commercial rental** (Sugarbush, Wurtsboro, Van Sant, Chilhowee, Seminole-Lake, Miami, Arizona Soaring, Mile High). Pay per hour plus tow. Expect a dual checkout flight with their CFIG (Certificated Flight Instructor, Glider) on the first visit, a logbook review, and increasingly your own renter insurance. Arizona Soaring requires hull cover of \$15k (1-26, 2-33) up to \$60k (G103) and \$100k (ASK-21); Seminole-Lake requires \$40k hull.
- **Guest or short-term membership** (Harris Hill board-approved guest, Skyline Visiting Member \$10/day for SSA club members, Pittsburgh temporary membership, Sandhill short-term guest, Mohawk 30-day limited, Texas Soaring visiting-pilot membership, Blue Ridge monthly guest, SVS 3-month intro). Needs an email ahead with SSA number and logbook, then a checkout.
- **Long-distance membership** (Adirondack \$650 + \$15/mo for members 120+ mi away; Finger Lakes \$550 + \$15/mo; Brandywine non-resident \$500 + \$35/mo). Pay once, then book like a local. This is the cheapest way to make a second home field.
- **Full membership only** (most other clubs). Worth it only for one second club you will visit often.

Standing prerequisites

- Current SSA (Soaring Society of America) membership.
- Non-owner glider renter policy (Costello, AVEMCO or AOPA) with hull limits sized to the most expensive glider you would rent; about \$60k-100k covers every operator here.
- Current logbook, flight review, and a record of each site checkout (the workbook has a column for this).
- Oxygen and wave-window briefing for wave sites (Mt Washington, Petersburg WV, Boulder).
- Mountain and density-altitude checkout for western sites (Boulder at 5,288 ft, Heber at 5,637 ft, Moriarty at 6,204 ft).

4. Relationship plan

Now, while pre-solo:

- Keep training at GBSC; sit-test the 1-34, L-23 and ASW-19 so you know your single-seat options at home.
- Use one weekend to take a dual lesson at Sugarbush (ridge and wave, 3:15 away). It gets you in the PW-6 and 2-33 and on their radar.
- Optionally a lesson at Wurtsboro to sit in their Grob 103 and ask for written rental and checkout rules.

After the Private Pilot Glider certificate:

- Buy a renter policy and keep SSA current.
- Van tier: rental checkouts at Sugarbush and Wurtsboro; join Adirondack as a long-distance member (tows only after that); email Mohawk about a limited membership for Greylock ridge days.
- Fly tier: checkout weekends at Chilhowee (set up a \$1,000 block account), Arizona Soaring (G103), and Seminole-Lake. Email Harris Hill, Skyline and Sandhill for guest status.
- Log every call and visit in the workbook's Contact Log so fleet and policy notes stay current.

5. The weekly decision (Wednesday/Thursday)

- Open the map file. Pick Saturday or Sunday and the midday hour, and switch layers: boundary layer height (thermal depth), estimated cloud base, CAPE (Convective Available Potential Energy, thunderstorm risk), low cloud, rain chance, and 850 hPa wind (about 5,000 ft MSL, the ridge and wave driver).

- Ridge days: 850 hPa wind 15-30 kt roughly perpendicular to the ridge (northwest for the Green Mountains, Greylock and Shawangunks). Wave: strong northwest flow with a stable layer above the ridges, typically after a cold front.
- Thermal days: boundary layer over about 5,000 ft AGL, cloud base high, low CAPE, little low cloud and rain.
- Cross-check with the soaring-specific forecasts linked from each site popup (SkySight, XC Skies, Windy, NWS area forecast discussion), then call the operator Thursday.

6. Gaps and caveats

- Many clubs publish nothing about visitors; 'Unknown, call' in the workbook means exactly that.
- Closed or not operating: Stowe Soaring (dissolved 2019), Ridge Soaring Gliderport, Julian PA (closed 2022), Turf Soaring AZ (closed), Southwest Soaring TX, Kutztown PA; Eastern Soaring Center WV is closed for 2026; Bermuda High is not scheduling new instruction; Skyline's home field FRR is closed for repaving until about mid-November 2026.
- Seminole-Lake Gliderport has been listed for sale since 2022 (relisted May 2025).
- Coordinates marked approximate in the workbook are within about a mile.
- Tall-pilot notes are general type reputation except where an operator stated a limit (CSA 6'1", SVS under 6'5", TSA ride limit 6'4").